Sleep Performance Toolkit

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01

How to use this toolkit

Good sleep comes mostly from timing and a handful of habits, and the basics cost nothing. The advice here draws on research and practical experience, and the habits with the strongest evidence come first.

- **Start with three things.** A fixed wake time, light outside soon after waking, and a caffeine cut-off. These give the largest return for the least effort.
- **Add more when you are ready.** Once the first three feel like routine, bring in others from the sections below.
- **Treat the times as starting points.** The times and temperatures are practical rules based on the research, and you can adjust them around your own schedule.

> WORTH KNOWING
> A single poor night is normal, and it is the pattern across several weeks that matters. Trying hard to sleep tends to make sleep worse, which is one reason this toolkit keeps the effort low.

02

Anchor the body clock

Your body clock runs a little longer than 24 hours and is reset each day mainly by light. The strongest signals are bright light soon after waking and dim light in the evening.

Morning light

- **Get outside within the first hour or two of waking.** Aim for 10 to 30 minutes, towards the longer end on an overcast day.
- **Outdoor light is far brighter than indoor light.** Even a grey morning is many times brighter than a typical kitchen or office, and a window weakens it considerably, so a few minutes outside count for more than longer beside a window.
- **On dark mornings, use a light therapy lamp.** If you cannot get outside, or the mornings are dark, a small light therapy lamp (sometimes sold as a seasonal affective light or daylight lamp) is a practical option and is easy to buy online (Amazon). Look for one that gives out a very bright light, commonly rated at around 10,000 lux, which is much closer to daylight than normal indoor lighting. Place it beside your laptop and let the light shine towards your face while you have your coffee or work through your first emails, and follow the distance and timing on the box. If you have an eye condition, check with your doctor first.
- **Attach a morning walk to something you already do.** Do your first couple of emails on your phone, write a few messages on your phone, make a call or do some stretching while you are outside.

A fixed wake time

Keep your wake time within about 30 minutes every day, including weekends, and let bedtime follow from it. Irregular sleep timing, including a big gap between weekday and weekend sleep, is linked with poorer heart health, so a steady wake time is a simple habit worth building.

After a late night, keep the wake time within an hour of normal and get your morning light. A long lie-in moves the body clock later and makes the next night harder.

When you travel

Use the same rule at your destination, with outdoor light in the morning and dim light in the evening, and move your meals and wake time to the new time zone as soon as you arrive.

03

Through the day

What you take in and when you move affects how easily sleep arrives eight to ten hours later.

HABIT	WHAT TO DO AND WHY
Caffeine	Finish caffeine at least 8 hours before bed, which is around 14:30 for a 22:30 bedtime. In one study, two to three cups of coffee taken 6 hours before bed cut sleep by more than an hour, and the people taking part did not notice. Eight hours gives you a safe gap, because even 6 hours was enough to disrupt sleep in that study.
Alcohol	If you drink, finish at least 3 hours before bed and keep to a couple of drinks. Alcohol helps many people fall asleep faster, but it makes the second half of the night lighter and more broken, and the effect grows with the amount. On a wearable you will often see a higher resting heart rate and poorer recovery scores on the nights you drink.
Exercise	Regular exercise improves sleep quality. Training in the evening is fine for most people, and the exception worth avoiding is a very hard session finishing within an hour of bed.
Evening meal	Finish a large meal 2 to 3 hours before bed. A small snack with some protein and carbohydrate is fine if you are hungry.

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The evening wind-down

The aim of the last 60 to 90 minutes is to lower the light, the temperature and the noise in your head, so the body can move into sleep.

STEP	WHAT TO DO AND WHY
Dim the lights	From about 90 minutes before bed, switch off overhead lights and use lamps. Turn down the lighting on your phone, laptop or iPad so the screen is darker. Bright light in the evening delays the body clock. Room brightness matters more than the screen itself, although email and news on a phone can keep your mind switched on, so set a time after which you stop checking work messages.
Cool, dark room	Aim for roughly 16 to 19°C with blackout curtains or an eye mask. Your body temperature needs to drop for sleep to start, and a cool room helps that happen.
Warm shower or bath	A warm shower or bath 1 to 2 hours before bed helps many people fall asleep faster, because your body cools down afterwards, which signals that it is time to sleep.

STEP	WHAT TO DO AND WHY
Quick head review	Spend a couple of minutes writing down what you need to do tomorrow, along with anything that is annoying you, bothering you or causing you anxiety. Get it all down on your phone or a piece of paper and leave it at that.
Optional supplement	If you want to try one supplement, magnesium glycinate is a reasonable option, typically 200 to 350mg of elemental magnesium in the evening. The research shows a modest benefit at best, so it helps some people and not others. Like all supplements and medications, check with your doctor first.

05

Settling the nervous system

Your body has two main settings. The fight or flight system raises your heart rate, alertness and muscle tension to meet demands such as deadlines coming up at work, projects, or difficult conversations that need to be had. The rest and digest system, which is your relax system, slows the heart and supports digestion, recovery and sleep. Many people spend long stretches of the day in fight or flight, and sleep comes more easily when rest and digest takes over in the evening.

> WHY SLOW BREATHING WORKS
> A long, slow breath out shifts your body towards the rest and digest system, which slows your heart rate and helps you settle. It is a useful tool in the evening and during a stressful day.

The physiological sigh

This is two breaths in followed by one long breath out. Take a deep breath in through your nose, then a second short breath in on top of it to fill your lungs, then breathe out slowly through your mouth for as long as is comfortable. That is one cycle, so repeat for 3 to 5 cycles.

Box breathing

Breathe in for 4 seconds, hold for 4 seconds, breathe out for 4 seconds and hold for 4 seconds. That is one cycle, so repeat for 3 to 5 cycles. Choose a count that feels comfortable, and stop if you feel light-headed.

Scrolling and new shows in the evening

Doom scrolling through social media or the news, and starting something new on Netflix, gives your brain a steady stream of novelty and bad news to react to, and this can keep the fight or flight system switched on late into the evening.

- **If you scroll, set a timer with a dead stop.** Decide how long you will spend before you start, set an alarm, and put the phone down when it goes.
- **Watch something you have watched before.** In practice, a familiar show has no novelty to wake you up or stimulate the fight or flight system, so it is easier to wind down with.

Other ways to shift gear

- **Mark the end of the working day.** A walk, a shower or a change of clothes tells your body that work is over. Research on switching off from work links it with better sleep.

— **Take short breaks during the day.** A few slow breaths between meetings stop the build-up of tension, so there is less to unwind at night.

— **Treat wearable data as a trend.** If you wear a tracker, look at the pattern across weeks and not a single night. Do not obsess about your trackers, because the world of over-optimisation will cause you more anxiety than it is worth.

06

If you are lying awake

Cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia, known as CBT-I, is the first treatment recommended by medical guidelines for long-term sleep problems, ahead of sleeping tablets. These are the parts you can use on your own.

— **Get up after about 20 minutes awake.** Go to another room, keep the lights low and do something quiet until you feel sleepy, then return. This teaches your brain to link the bed with sleep.

— **Keep the bed for sleep.** Leave work, email and the news outside the bedroom.

— **Turn the clock away.** Checking the time raises alertness and worry.

— **Hold your wake time after a bad night.** Avoid sleeping in or going to bed hours early to catch up, because this weakens the pressure to sleep the next night.

> WORTH SAYING
> If you snore loudly, someone has noticed you stop breathing in your sleep, you wake with a headache, or you feel unrefreshed after a full night, speak to your GP, because sleep apnoea is common and can be treated. The same applies if poor sleep has lasted more than three months, so check with your GP.

07

Where to start

See which of these tools is the most doable for you to start with. Do not try to do everything at once. Pick one or two that are realistic for you and your life, and start there.

Three good places to start

☐ **A fixed wake time.** Within about 30 minutes every day, including weekends.

☐ **Light outside soon after waking.** 10 to 30 minutes, with your first emails, messages or a phone call.

☐ **A caffeine cut-off.** At least 8 hours before bed.

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